

This could easily have been dismissed as an adolescent crush, but Hector never forgot her and renewed their friendship in the 1860s.

In 1821, Berlioz began his studies at the medical school in Paris. He did his best to follow his parents' wishes, but a clash of wills became inevitable. For the most part, this was down to Hector's genuine distaste for the horrors of the dissection room. At the same time, his commitment to music grew rapidly, as he enjoyed the cultural benefits of living in the capital. He visited the Opéra and the theater and, from 1822, he began to frequent the library of the Conservatoire.



BATON

This conductor's baton belonged to Hector Berlioz. It is now on display at the museum dedicated to the composer in the house where he was born in La Côte-Saint-André, Isère, southeastern France.

Berlioz graduated from medical school in 1824, when he was finally compelled to inform his parents that he was going to make his career in music. They already suspected this, but were still horrified. His father cut his allowance, while his puritanical mother even laid a curse on him. By this stage, Berlioz had already started composing, supplementing his meager income with some music criticism. His first significant production was his *Messe solennelle* (Solemn Mass).